

FINE ART OF FINESSE

For **Maxime Montay,** Executive Chef at Monique, the kitchen is a precision-tuned laboratory where engineering meets artistry. With a background as a Food Process Engineer, Montay brings a clinical discipline to his French bakeries across Delhi NCR. At Monique, the philosophy is simple, a kitchen must be spotless to be soulful. "I believe it's important to keep your main work areas very tidy and clean as it makes one more efficient and it also opens your creativity somehow," he says. By merging rigorous French technique with a minimalist aesthetic, he ensures finesse is baked into the very layout.

ENGINEERING THE FLOW

Montay's design DNA is rooted in a clean freak approach to organisation, viewing a well-ordered workspace as the primary fuel for innovation. He prioritises high ceilings and natural light. "It's a choice one makes because keeping a space for a window is that much space less for a storage rack," he explains. In fact, he utilises Vastu principles as a practical tool for functional design. He creates equilibrium by separating fire elements like ovens from water stations like sinks. By placing heavy storage in the south west and keeping north east walls light, he ensures a natural flow. "I also avoid black or dark tones in the kitchen which gives that feeling of an enclosed space and prefer beige or white," he notes.